



Turn Out Those Lights!

On his twenty-first birthday, contract killer Jackie Estecado underwent some strange changes (no, no, not *those*—they happen earlier)—he watched his friends die while he figured out how to work a shotgun, and stared in amazement as two snake-like creatures and a number of tentacles sprouted from his back and started whispering highly un-sweet nothings in his ear. Thus begins the story of *The Darkness*, and you must play as Jackie and figure out what this Darkness is, why it's infesting you, and, of course, kill people. And other... beings. That'll teach them to make fun of your hair.

The Darkness is a well-made game—I'll give it that. It looks good—even if the HDR effects are a tad overdone—

and the background score is brilliant. And it's definitely got style, right down to the loading screens—instead of boring “Loading...”, you get little bites of mafia wisdom from Jackie, and the game itself has you shuttling between the real world and a version of hell where World War I never ends. Jackie sometimes “sees things,” making for some very *F.E.A.R.*-esque heebeegeebee-inducing moments.

The concept of this dark force itself is interesting. The creature feeds off shadows to gather dark energy, which in turn protects you from bullets and other forms of harm. You can also use one of the snakes to sneak around and kill enemies in beautifully gruesome glory. And then comes the best part—to gain more darkness levels, you have to consumes enemies' hearts. Ah,

the merits of evil... You can also summon darklings: little minions, who lend a little comedy to the game (à la *Overlord*)—to do your bidding, be it blowing up things, riddling enemies with bullets or other activities of general carnage. This is all very well the first time you encounter it, but *The Darkness* suffers from some very annoying flaws.

First, there's the matter that first-person shooters and consoles don't go well together. Second, the story—it drags awfully in places, especially the beginning, which tempted me to throw my controller away and call the whole thing off.

Thirdly—and this is the silliest—to keep the Darkness from being harmed by the light, you end up worrying more about lights in the room than enemies. It's like being

trapped in a very stupid arcade shooter. Fourthly, this game, too, doesn't escape some of the annoying bugs that plague so many FPSes—you can be stopped dead in your tracks by a lowly tree-root or knee-high obstacles that four-year olds wouldn't think twice about: the same old nonsense. Tch, tch.

Finally, the enemy AI is quite pathetic. The fact that I was more worried about the lights than enemies should have given you some clue to that end.

The Darkness is a decent game—the evil, it gets addictive—but not beyond the first couple of hours. There are much better things to do with your 360. Like play *Gears of War*.

nimish_chandiramani
@thinkdigit.com

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Contact: xbox360@redington.co.in; Price: Rs 1895; Platform: Xbox 360

